history, and understanding how the Great Game should be defined is essential. That is not to say that the definition need be rigid. In fact, the concept of the Great Game is much more fluid than historians have hitherto realised. While debate on this subject has nearly always centred on dates and events as defining the Game, it will be asserted that these were manifestations of a certain state of mind, and that it is this state of mind that should be focused on if one wishes to truly understand the Great Game.[3]

Before looking at the Great Game as a mental process, however, it would be useful to understand something of the traditional definitions of the subject. Although, typically, the Great Game refers to the rivalry between Britain and Russia for dominance in Asia between the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, since the term has grown organically there is little agreement on the specific parameters of the Game. For some, the ambitions of Peter the Great towards Asia in the early eighteenth century was the start of the Great Game, for Russia at least. Yet, for Britain, it was the potential alliance between Napoleon and Tsar Paul I in 1801, which was to really initiate the fear of Russian expansion – a crucial component of the Great Game.[4] Others have started in the early 1800s with the adventures of William Moorcroft, the British veterinary surgeon and horse-trader turned explorer and Great Game advocate.[5] Still others have much narrower definitions, believing that the Great Game effectively began and ended with the First Anglo-Afghan War (1839–42).[6] Certainly, this conflict was one of the key events of the Great Game and had a large impact on the British psyche. It also epitomised the nature of British reaction to Russian activity in Asia, the entire affair being precipitated by Russia's attempts to extend its influence within Afghanistan.

Largely in response to Afghanistan's perceived favouritism towards Russia, in 1839 Britain decided to invade that country and replace the current emir, Dost Mohammed, with a much more compliant Afghan ruler. While this initial aim was met, and shah Shujah successfully placed on the Afghan throne, in 1841 an uprising by the Afghan people took place in response to the continued presence of British military personnel in Afghanistan. The British explorer, Alexander Burnes, who had become famous for his travels into Bokhara a few years earlier and who was now a political agent in Kabul, was among the first British victims of the Afghan mob. Within a